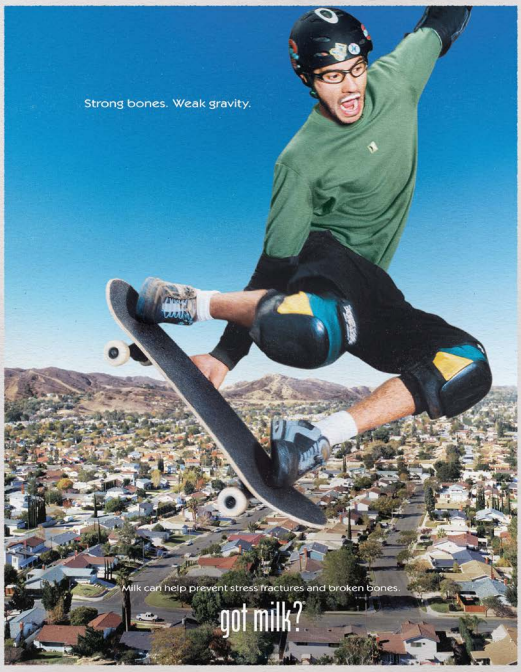
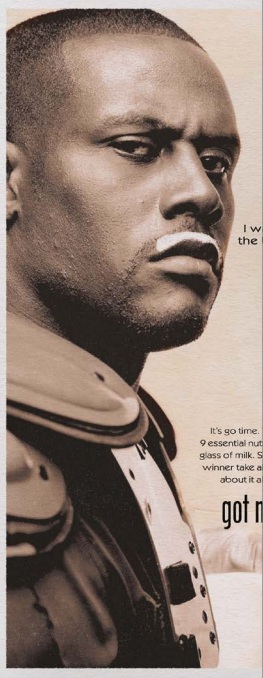










percent of Americans thought milk was healthy—but rather two other factors: Americans were dining out more, skipping the home-cooked meals that would've been accompanied by milk or juice. Many Americans also thought of milk as a kid's beverage, and in the post-Baby Boom years, the percentage of the U.S. population under age 18 was shrinking.

More critically, though, soft drinks, bottled iced tea, and bottled water were crowding out milk cartons in supermarket cases—the result of extremely well-funded branding and advertising. Soda consumption in America was crescendoing toward its 1998 peak, the year when Americans drank 53 gallons per person. "Milk was being outpackaged, outspent, and outflanked," Manning wrote. Americans had "shifted gears and left it behind."

That was the panorama when the board handed Manning a whopping $25 million ($51.3 million in today's dollars) to create its first ad campaign. Manning teamed up with Goodby, Silverstein & Partners, an agency whose idea it was to skip the "good for you" talk and remind consumers that they loved milk so much, they'd panic if it ever went missing.

The earliest Got Milk? TV spots were unlike any government-sponsored ads America had ever seen. In one bizarre sketch, an Alexander Hamilton buff receives a surprise call offering him $10,000 to name Hamilton's assassin—problem was, he was eating a peanut butter sandwich and had run out of milk to clear his throat. (A young Michael Bay, who went on to make blockbusters like Bad Boys and Transformers, directed the spot.) Then there was the dad who ran out of milk at breakfast time and had to decide whether the baby or the cat should sacrifice their meal. The ads were witty, weird, and occasionally downright wicked. And they were such

GotMilk (1995 - 2010)





